AJP Policy Document

Protect wildlife from anthropogenic harms

Wild animals are frequently harmed due to the design of urban structures, roads, and the activities of people who are often unaware of their impacts. To address these issues, AJP wishes to see greater integration of wildlife considerations into urban planning, road design and signage by way of impact assessments. This would require greater collaboration between local councils, urban planners, conservation groups and communities to develop wildlife-friendly infrastructure.

Many wild animals, native and introduced, inhabit towns and cities and are frequently harmed by their human-centric design. For example, windows can be made with glass that is more visible to birds, thereby reducing collisions.[1] Human-wildlife conflicts can be addressed in nonviolent ways, such as through nonviolent population control of pigeons, rather than using spikes to restrict perching.[2] Generally speaking, by considering animals in the design of urban structures and areas, harms to wild animals can be reduced or avoided altogether. This may often require collaboration between local councils, urban planners, conservation groups and communities.

This is particularly important in the design of roads, which frequently kill and injure wild animals. Measures such as wildlife crossings, barriers, and lower speed limits can reduce these harms,[3] and research into wildlife movement patterns can inform road and urban planning that prioritises animal safety. While the *Wildlife Act 1953* requires permits for developments that may disturb or kill protected species, its focus remains on species conservation and habitat protection rather than the welfare of individual animals, leaving a gap between conservation law and animal welfare.

An important aspect of making urban areas friendly to wild animals is by the integration of habitat. This may involve planting native species, connecting fragmented habitats

[1] American Bird Conservancy. (2024). *Bird-smart glass testing program*. https://abcbirds.org/glass-collisions/testing/

[2] Animal Aid. (2024, November 8). The case for the humane control of pigeons. https://www.animalaid.org.uk/case-humane-control-pigeons/; Animal Welfare Institute. (2014, Winter). Bird birth control: Effective, but underutilized management tool. *AWI Quarterly*. https://awionline.org/awi-quarterly/2014-winter/bird-birth-control-effective-underutilized-management-tool

[3] See e.g. Rytwinski, T., Soanes, K., Jaeger, J. A. G., Fahrig, L., Findlay, C. S., Houlahan, J., van der Ree, R., & van der Grift, E. A. (2016). How effective is road mitigation at reducing road-kill? A meta-analysis. *PLOS ONE, 11*(11), e0166941. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0166941

through wildlife corridors, or creating green roofs and pocket parks. Such measures not only provide shelter and food for animals but also improve the quality of life for people.

Lastly, signs warning people of sensitive wildlife, or educating people about how to behave around them, need to be informative, highly visible, and strategically placed to maximise their effectiveness in both rural and urban areas.

Key Objectives:

1. Require animal welfare impact assessments to be carried out in the design of all roading and urban development projects. Enact stricter regulations mandating designs that better protect wild animals, especially where they are particularly vulnerable.
2. Raise awareness of impacts on wild animals through education and public engagement, encouraging more compassionate wildlife-friendly behaviour and fostering community-led conservation efforts.
3. Promote rewilding projects in urban areas, using native species where possible, and the connection of existing habitats through wildlife corridors.
4. Fund scientific research to better understand the impacts of roads and urban structures on wild animals, and the development of solutions to mitigate these impacts.